DBT AT BRIGHTON CAMHS

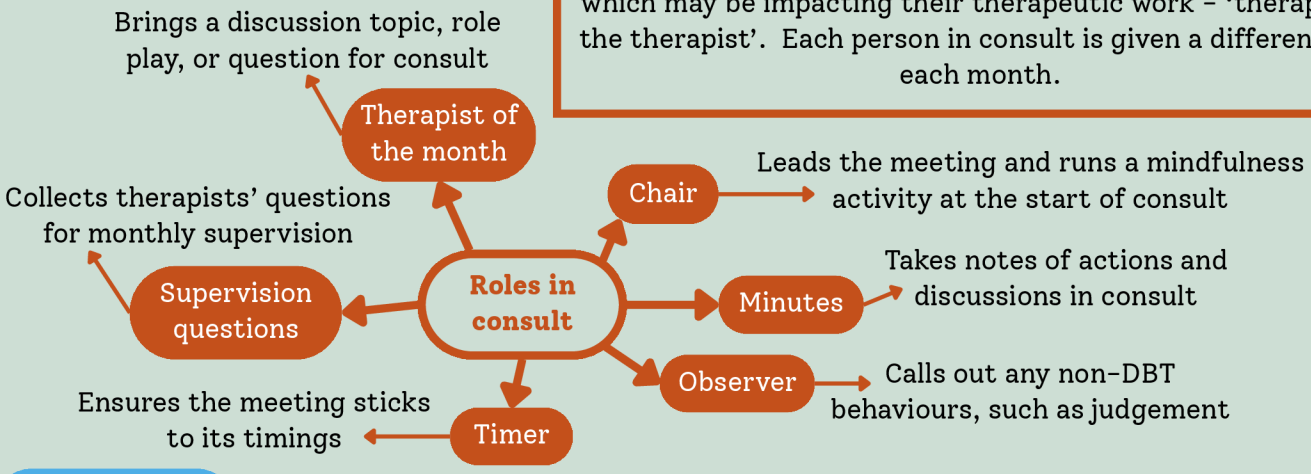
What is DBT?

DBT stands for Dialectical Behavioural Therapy, and is offered at CAMHS under the 'Emotional Intensity' Pathway to young people who are having difficulty regulating their emotions. DBT aims to provide people with skills to replace problem behaviours, such as self-harm and relational difficulties, to make a life worth living.

'Dialectical' describes holding two opposing ideas in mind at the same time, considering them both to be true and so finding a new understanding of a situation.

DBT Consult

An essential part of DBT is the DBT Consult – a weekly meeting between the therapists (and the placement student). Here, therapists can reflect on any challenges they are experiencing which may be impacting their therapeutic work – 'therapy for the therapist'. Each person in consult is given a different role each month.



Skills Class

Young people in DBT attend both one-to-one therapy, and a weekly skills class group with a parent or carer. Placement students are involved in helping facilitate skills class, but are not involved in the one-to-one therapy sessions. Skills class consists of a mindfulness activity, review of the previous week's homework, and then the teaching of a new DBT skill. The role of a placement student in skills class is to help set up and buy snacks for the break, take turns leading the mindfulness activity, and contribute to discussions. Skills class is 16 weeks long in total, and covers 5 key themes:

- Core mindfulness
- Interpersonal effectiveness
- Emotion regulation
- Walking the middle path
- Distress tolerance

Example DBT Skill: TIPP

The TIPP skill is used to manage extreme emotions, and consists of:

T – Temperature: Tip the temperature of your face with cold water to calm down fast

I – Intense exercise: Expend your body's stored-up physical energy with intense aerobic exercise

P – Paced breathing: Slow your pace of breathing down

P – Progressive muscle relaxation: Tense and relax each muscle group

Criteria for DBT at CAMHS

To be eligible for a DBT referral at CAMHS, a young person must have difficulties with some of the following:

- Suicidal ideation, suicide attempts, or self-harm
- Unstable and intense interpersonal relationships
- Impulsivity
- Unstable mood
- Identity disturbance
- Frantic efforts to avoid real or imagined abandonment
- Difficulty controlling anger
- Chronic feelings of emptiness

References: DBT Skills Manual for Adolescents (Jill H. Rathus & Alec L. Miller), Running an effective DBT Consultation Team (Sayrs, 2019)